ETH-03 · CODE OF ETHICS

Reporting numbers under pressure — a casebook

Five fictitious dilemmas, the clause that governs each, the options ranked, and the words to say

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

Summary

Five constructed, explicitly fictitious cases in which a project controls professional is pressed to report something other than what the evidence shows: a forecast softened before a board meeting, an accrual deferred to protect a monthly cost performance index, float concealed to preserve a completion date, a progress claim measured generously at year-end, and a caveat removed after sign-off. Each case sets out the situation, the pressure, the clauses of the PCI code that govern it, the practical options ranked from best to worst, and the words a professional can actually say in the room. All figures are illustrative.

About this document

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Contents

Reporting numbers under pressure — a casebook

In one paragraph. This casebook takes five situations in which a project controls professional is pressed to report something other than what the evidence shows — a forecast softened before a board meeting, an accrual deferred to protect a monthly cost performance index, float concealed to preserve a completion date, a progress claim measured generously at year-end, and a caveat removed after sign-off — and works each one through in the same structure: the situation, the pressure, what the Code requires, the practical options ranked from best to worst, and the words a professional can say in the room. Every case is invented for teaching. Every figure is illustrative.

Who this is for. Cost engineers, planners, quantity surveyors and controls managers who will be asked one of these questions at some point in their career, and their managers, who will be the ones asking.

1. A note on the cases, and on what they are not

Every case in this document is fictitious. The situations are constructed to teach; the organisations, roles, projects and numbers are invented; no case describes, is based on, or alludes to any real project, employer, client or person. Nothing here is a report of anything that happened.

They are written in a deliberately unhelpful shape: in each one, the person applying the pressure has a reasonable argument, the number in dispute is genuinely uncertain, and the professional cannot afford a dramatic gesture. That is the realistic case. Dilemmas in which a villain demands a lie are easy and rare.

Three things recur across all five, and they are the reason the casebook exists.

The request is always about presentation, never about truth. Nobody says falsify the forecast. They say is there a way to present this that does not derail the meeting. There usually is, and sometimes it is entirely legitimate — which is what makes the question hard.

The number is usually within a defensible range. The pressure is applied at the edge of that range, not outside it, and then applied again next month from the new edge. Ratchets are how reporting positions drift.

The deciding question is not "is this figure defensible?" but "would the person relying on it change their decision if they could see how it was produced?" That is the test in `ETH-01 §3.1` under materially misleading, and it resolves four of the five cases below on its own.

A note on currency and rounding. Figures are stated in a generic **currency unit (CU)** so that no jurisdiction's tax, accounting or contractual treatment is implied. Money is rounded to the nearest whole unit; indices are shown to three decimal places; percentages of a stated base are shown to one decimal place. Every calculation shows its substitution.

2. Case one — the forecast the director wants softened

Fictitious case. Illustrative figures.

2.1 The situation

You are the project controls manager on a delivery programme with an approved budget at completion of **CU 120,000,000**. The board meets on Thursday. Your team's estimate at completion, built bottom up from committed cost, accrued cost, remaining work priced at current rates, and a risk allowance, is **CU 128,400,000**.

That is an overrun of:

```
128,400,000 − 120,000,000 = 8,400,000
8,400,000 ÷ 120,000,000 = 0.070 = 7.0 % of approved budget
```

The programme's governance rule — a rule you helped write — requires the board to be told when the forecast overrun exceeds 5 % of approved budget. Five per cent of CU 120,000,000 is CU 6,000,000, so the threshold sits at a forecast of CU 126,000,000. Your number crosses it.

On Tuesday the project director asks you to "look again" at the forecast and see whether it can be "presented at around 122". That figure implies an overrun of CU 2,000,000, or 1.7 % of approved budget, comfortably inside the threshold.

```
122,000,000 − 120,000,000 = 2,000,000
2,000,000 ÷ 120,000,000 = 0.017 = 1.7 % of approved budget
```

The gap between the two forecasts is **CU 6,400,000** — the difference between a report that triggers board scrutiny and one that does not.

2.2 The pressure

The director is not corrupt and is not asking you to invent anything. Their argument is genuinely arguable: two of your assumptions are conservative, a commercial settlement is expected within six weeks that may recover part of the exposure, and a recovery plan is being drafted. They point out — correctly — that a forecast is a judgement, that your CU 128,400,000 has a range around it, and that CU 122,000,000 is inside that range. They add that going to the board with 7 % will trigger an intervention that will consume the team for a month and make recovery less likely.

You also know three things they have not said: the board approved this budget nine months ago on the strength of your predecessor's forecast; the director's variable remuneration is affected by programme outturn; and if you report 122 and the settlement does not land, you will be reporting a larger overrun in three months with less credibility.

2.3 What the Code requires

- `ETH-01 §5.1.3` — a forecast must reflect performance to date and honest assumptions. **A number selected because it is acceptable, and justified afterwards, is a breach even if it later turns out to be right.** This is the clause that decides the case: the sequence matters, not only the result.

- `ETH-01 §5.2` — assumptions, basis and exclusions travel with the number, in a form the recipient will actually see.
- `ETH-01 §5.3` — the test applies to the impression created, not only to each figure.
- `ETH-01 §7.3.3` — an instruction to change a number is not improper merely because it is unwelcome. If the director's assumptions are better than yours, adopting them is correct professional practice.

The line between §7.3.3 and §5.1.3 is the whole case, and it is drawn in one place: **is the change driven by evidence, or by the destination?** A settlement with a signed heads of terms and a defined value is evidence. A settlement that is "expected" is an assumption — and an assumption may be adopted, but it must be visible, attributed and reversible.

2.4 The options, ranked

1. Report the honest forecast, and give the director the recovery narrative they actually need. Present CU 128,400,000 as the current forecast, with the range, the assumptions and — critically — a clearly separated statement of what would have to be true for the outturn to be CU 122,000,000: the settlement value, its probability, its timing, and the recovery actions with owners and dates. This is better for the director than the softened number, because it puts the recovery case in front of the board as a plan rather than as an unexplained improvement. It also protects them: they can say they disclosed early.

2. Re-run the forecast with the director's assumptions made explicit, and report both. Show the base case at CU 128,400,000 and a stated-assumption case at CU 122,000,000, with the assumptions named in the same table. Legitimate, and honest, provided neither is presented as the forecast without the other and the base case is not relegated to an appendix. Ranked second only because two numbers in front of a board invite the wrong one to be quoted.

3. Adopt a genuinely better assumption where the director has actually persuaded you. If the challenge exposes a conservative allowance you cannot defend, change it — and record why, in the basis of estimate, before the meeting rather than after it. The forecast may legitimately fall to, say, CU 126,900,000. It falls to whatever the evidence supports, not to the threshold.

4. Report the softened number with a caveat buried in the pack. Not acceptable. This is the option people actually take, and it fails `ETH-01 §5.3` precisely: every figure is defensible and the document misleads.

5. Report CU 122,000,000 as the forecast. A breach of §5.1.3, and one that compounds: next month you either report the same number you no longer believe, or you explain a CU 6,400,000 movement that did not happen this month.

2.5 What you actually say

> "I can't put 122 up as the forecast, because I'd be starting from the answer. What I can do is show the board the bridge: base case 128.4, and what has to land to get to 122 — the settlement at its expected value, and the four recovery actions with owners. If the settlement is signed before Thursday, I'll rebuild the forecast on it and the number moves properly. If you want, I'll draft the recovery slide with you this afternoon so it lands as a plan rather than as a variance."

Then, whatever is decided, send one short factual note the same day: the forecast you provided, the basis, and what was agreed for the pack. Not an accusation — a record. `ETH-01 §5.8`.

2.6 If you are overruled

If the pack goes out at CU 122,000,000 over your objection, you have not breached the Code by being overruled (`ETH-01 §6.4`), but three obligations remain live. Your own record must show the forecast you supplied and to whom (`§5.8`). You must not personally sign or present the softened figure as your forecast (`§5.1.1`). And if the misstatement is material and goes to the board unaltered, you must escalate once through the channel that exists — audit, governance, or the sponsor — and record it (`§5.9.3`). That sequence is available to someone who cannot afford to resign, which is the point of it.

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3. Case two — the accrual that slips into next month

Fictitious case. Illustrative figures.

3.1 The situation

You are the cost engineer for a work package with a budget at completion of **CU 96,000,000**. At the month-14 cut-off your figures are:

Measure	Value at cut-off
Earned value (EV), cumulative	CU 42,000,000
Actual cost (AC), cumulative, invoices received	CU 41,000,000
Subcontractor work performed, not yet invoiced	CU 1,900,000

The CU 1,900,000 is not in dispute. The work was done before cut-off, the field engineer has signed the measurement sheet, and the invoice is late because the subcontractor's commercial team is short-staffed. Under the entity's accounting policy it should be accrued into month 14.

The reporting rule on this programme flags any package amber where the cumulative cost performance index falls below 1.000.

With the accrual excluded:

```
CPI = EV ÷ AC = 42,000,000 ÷ 41,000,000 = 1.024
```

With the accrual included:

```
CPI = EV ÷ AC = 42,000,000 ÷ 42,900,000 = 0.979
```

The commercial manager suggests that since the invoice "hasn't arrived", the cost "isn't ours yet", and it can go into month 15 — where it will be diluted by a larger cost base and, with luck, offset by a productivity improvement everyone expects.

3.2 The pressure

This one is dangerous because it is dressed as a technicality, and because it is reversible. Nothing is being invented and nothing is being destroyed; a cost is merely landing in the next box. Everyone involved expects the numbers to catch up. The person suggesting it is not asking you to lie — they are asking you to apply a timing judgement in the direction that helps.

Two things make it worse than it looks.

It moves the index across the threshold that governs attention. The whole purpose of the amber flag is to direct scrutiny to packages performing below plan. A package at 0.979 gets scrutiny; a package at 1.024 does not. The deferral does not soften a message, it deletes it.

It moves the forecast by more than the accrual. Using the cost-performance-index method for the estimate at completion — one of several defensible methods, and the one this programme's reporting standard uses — the effect is:

```
EAC = BAC ÷ CPI
Including the accrual:  EAC = 96,000,000 ÷ 0.979 = 96,000,000 × (42,900,000 ÷ 42,000,000) = 98,057,143
Excluding the accrual:  EAC = 96,000,000 ÷ 1.024 = 96,000,000 × (41,000,000 ÷ 42,000,000) = 93,714,286
Difference = 98,057,143 − 93,714,286 = 4,342,857
4,342,857 ÷ 96,000,000 = 0.045 = 4.5 % of budget at completion
```

Assumption stated with the answer: this estimate at completion assumes the remaining work is performed at the cumulative cost performance index — see `BPG-09 — Estimate at completion` for when that assumption is and is not appropriate. The point stands under any method that uses cumulative actual cost: a deferred accrual of CU 1,900,000 changes the reported forecast by roughly **CU 4.34 million**, or about 4.5 % of budget at completion. A CU 1.9 million timing decision is moving a CU 4.3 million forecast.

3.3 What the Code requires

- `ETH-01 §5.4.1` — cost incurred in a period is reported in that period, under the accounting framework and cut-off policy applying to the entity.
- `ETH-01 §5.4.2` — deferring a known cost **in order to improve a reported metric** is a breach regardless of whether it later reverses. The reversal is not the mitigation; it is the mechanism.
- `ETH-01 §5.4.3` — where a genuine timing judgement exists, the judgement, its grounds and its effect on the headline metrics are disclosed.
- `ETH-01 §4.1` — integrity of the numbers, of which cut-off discipline is the least glamorous and most frequently breached part.

Note what §5.4.3 permits. If the accrual were genuinely uncertain — a disputed measure, an unagreed rate, a contested quantity — a decision to hold it out of the period could be entirely proper. What makes this case a breach is that the reason offered is the effect on the index, not the quality of the evidence.

3.4 The options, ranked

1. Accrue it, report the index at 0.979, and lead with the explanation. The amber flag is not the bad news; the underperformance is. Report the accrual, the index, the resulting forecast, and the one-page reason: which activities underperformed, by how much, what is being done. A package explained is a package trusted.

2. Accrue it and add a like-for-like note. Where the previous month's report was not on a consistent accrual basis, say so and show both bases for one period, so the movement is not misread as a sudden collapse. Fixing a cut-off weakness openly is legitimate; doing it silently is not.

3. Escalate the systemic problem separately. If invoices routinely arrive after cut-off, that is a process defect creating a monthly temptation. Raise it as a controls issue — a standing accrual process with the subcontractor's measurement sheets as the trigger — so the judgement stops being made under pressure each month. Ranked third because it does not resolve this month.

4. Defer it and flag it in a footnote. Not acceptable. The index is what will be read; a footnote does not repair a metric that has crossed a control threshold. Fails §5.3 and §5.4.2.

5. Defer it silently. A clear breach of §5.4.2, and the one that is easiest to prove afterwards, because the measurement sheet is dated and the invoice will eventually arrive with a service period on it.

3.5 What you actually say

> "The work was done in month 14 and it's measured, so it accrues in month 14 — if I move it, the index isn't a measure of anything. Yes, it takes us to 0.979 and the package goes amber. Let me put the reason next to it: it's the two shifts we lost on the mechanical face and a re-work item. If we report it now with the recovery plan, amber is a controlled position. If we defer it and report it in month 15 alongside whatever month 15 does, we lose the ability to explain it at all."

And if the answer is "put it in next month anyway": that instruction should be given by the person who owns the accounting policy, in writing, with their reason. Most requests of this kind do not survive the sentence "can you confirm that in an email so I can reference it in the working papers?" — which is not a threat, merely the record `ETH-01 §5.8` requires you to keep.

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4. Case three — the float that disappears

Fictitious case. Illustrative figures.

4.1 The situation

You are the planning engineer on a plant project. Contractual mechanical completion is programme **day 610**. This month's update, with progress applied and logic unchanged, calculates mechanical completion at **day 628** — eighteen days late.

The project manager does not dispute the progress. They ask for two changes before the report is issued:

1. Apply a finish no later than constraint to the mechanical completion milestone at day 610, so the reported date matches the contract; and
2. Reduce four downstream commissioning activities whose durations currently total **46 days** to a total of **28 days**, on the basis that "we will resource up".

```
46 − 28 = 18 days of duration removed
18 ÷ 46 = 0.391 = a 39.1 % reduction in the remaining commissioning durations
```

No additional resource has been identified, no cost has been added, and no method statement has changed. Separately, the electrical containment path currently shows 24 days of total float, and you have been asked to "use some of that" by extending its activities to absorb the slip — which would leave the path with zero protection while showing an on-time finish.

4.2 The pressure

This is the case practitioners rationalise most easily, for three reasons. Schedules are models, and models involve choices. Compression is a real technique. And the requested output — an on-time completion date — is what everybody is trying to achieve anyway, so producing it feels like alignment rather than misstatement.

The pressure is amplified by the fact that a late date in the report has contractual consequences that a late date in reality does not yet have. Reporting day 628 may trigger a notice obligation, a liquidated-damages conversation, or a client intervention. Reporting day 610 defers all of that — for a month.

4.3 What the Code requires

- `ETH-01 §5.6.1` — a schedule represents the plan as it is genuinely intended to be executed, with logic, durations and constraints a competent reviewer could reconstruct.
- `ETH-01 §5.6.2` — a certificant must not conceal or absorb float, apply artificial constraints, break logic or manipulate durations **in order to make a forecast completion date agree with a required date**. All three requests fall inside this clause.
- `ETH-01 §5.6.3` — where the honest calculated completion is later than the required completion, that fact is reported; mitigation is proposed as mitigation, with its cost, risk and owner, not presented as though it had already happened.
- `ETH-01 §5.2.1` — the basis travels with the number. A schedule whose constraints are invisible to the reader has no basis attached.

The constraint request also has a second-order effect worth naming to the project manager, because it is the argument most likely to land: **float that has been consumed to hide a slip is no longer available to absorb the next one.** After the change, the electrical path has zero protection and the report says the project is on time. The next disruption — of any size — becomes an immediate contractual date failure with no warning, and the report that should have provided the warning has been configured not to.

4.4 The options, ranked

1. Report day 628, and present compression as a costed option. The honest forward pass is the report. Alongside it, present the compression genuinely: which four activities, what additional resource, what it costs, what risk it adds, who owns it, and what the completion date becomes if approved and resourced. That is a mitigation plan. Approve it, resource it, and the durations change legitimately in next month's update.

2. Report day 628 and quantify the exposure precisely. Eighteen days, on which paths, driven by which activities, with the float position on the near-critical paths stated so the reader can see how much protection remains. A planner who reports a slip and its anatomy is doing the job; one who reports only the date invites the shoot-the-messenger response.

3. Model the constrained scenario as an explicitly labelled scenario. A separate, named scenario file showing what would have to be true to finish at day 610 is a legitimate analytical product, and often persuasive. It is not the schedule, it is never issued as the schedule, and the labelling is not negotiable.

4. Apply the constraint and mention it in the narrative. Not acceptable. Readers of a programme read dates and float, not narrative. Fails §5.6.2 directly.

5. Compress the durations with no basis, or absorb the electrical float. The most damaging option, because it destroys the schedule's usefulness as a warning system while leaving it looking healthy. It also tends to be discovered later — by a delay analyst, in a claim, with the audit trail of exactly who changed what and when.

4.5 What you actually say

> "I can produce a programme that finishes on day 610, but only by constraining the milestone or cutting eighteen days out of commissioning durations without a resource change — and either way the programme stops being a forecast. What I'd rather give you is this: the update says 628, here are the three activities driving it, and here's the compression option costed, with the electrical path float shown. If we approve the resource, the durations change and the date moves for a real reason. If we constrain it now, we lose the twenty-four days of float on electrical and we won't see the next slip until it's a date failure."

If the change is imposed anyway, the record matters more here than in any other case in this book, because scheduling software preserves the evidence. Note the version you issued, the constraint or duration change you were instructed to apply, who instructed it, and the date. `ETH-01 §5.8` and `§5.9.2`.

5. Case four — the generous measure at year-end

Fictitious case. Illustrative figures.

5.1 The situation

You are the quantity surveyor for a piping installation package with a value of **CU 12,000,000**. The agreed rules of credit for the package are:

Step	Credit
Fabrication of spools	30 %
Erection	50 %
Testing and reinstatement	20 %

At the December measure, fabrication is complete and the field engineer's verified erection quantity is **82 %** of the erection scope. Testing has not started.

```
Fabrication:  100 % × 30 = 30.0 points
Erection:      82 % × 50 = 41.0 points
Testing:        0 % × 20 =  0.0 points
Assessed completion = 30.0 + 41.0 = 71.0 %
```

The application for payment being prepared claims **78 %**. To reach 78 % under the same rules of credit, erection would have to be at:

```
(78 − 30) ÷ 50 = 48 ÷ 50 = 0.96 = 96 % erected
```

Against 82 % verified. The commercial lead's justification is that spools for the remaining sections are fabricated, delivered to site and "effectively installed", and that the difference will be true within three weeks anyway.

The value at stake:

```
Each percentage point of the package = 12,000,000 ÷ 100 = CU 120,000
Claim difference = (78 − 71) × 120,000 = 7 × 120,000 = CU 840,000
Cross-check via the erection step = (96 % − 82 %) × 50 % × 12,000,000 = 0.14 × 6,000,000 = CU 840,000
```

5.2 The pressure

The timing is not incidental. This is the year-end measure, it feeds a revenue recognition position, and the difference between 71 % and 78 % on this package is one of several similar adjustments across the portfolio. The argument offered is a real one: material delivered to site is value transferred in some contractual regimes, and the work will genuinely be done shortly.

The reason it is nonetheless a breach is narrow and decisive. The rules of credit for this package give **no credit for delivery** — 30 % for fabrication, which has been taken in full, and 50 % for erection, which is measured on what is erected. The claim is not applying a different valid method; it is applying the agreed method to quantities that do not exist yet.

Note also that if delivery genuinely warranted credit, the correct professional route is to propose a change to the rules of credit, agreed with the counterparty and applied consistently to every package, going forward. That route is available, legitimate, and slower — which is precisely why it is not the one being suggested three days before the cut-off.

5.3 What the Code requires

- `ETH-01 §5.5.1` — progress is measured by the rule of credit that applies to the work package, applied consistently, and evidenced.
- `ETH-01 §5.5.2` — a certificant must not adopt a more generous basis **because the period is a reporting boundary**, nor apply rules of credit selectively across packages to reach a target percentage.
- `ETH-01 §5.5.3` — where measured and claimed progress differ, the difference is reported, not netted away.
- `ETH-01 §4.5` and `§7.2` — advocacy for your employer's commercial position is legitimate; asserting as fact a quantity that has not been installed is not.
- `ETH-01 §5.4.2` — accelerating the recognition of progress across a period boundary to improve a reported position is the mirror image of case two, and is caught by the same clause.

5.4 The options, ranked

1. Claim 71 %, and put the delivered-materials position in front of the counterparty properly. If materials on site are genuinely worth something under the contract, claim them under whatever provision applies to materials — separately, transparently, and with the evidence —

rather than by inflating an erection percentage. This frequently recovers more than the disputed 7 points, and it survives scrutiny.

2. Claim 71 % and propose a rules-of-credit change for future periods. Argue the principle openly and prospectively, with the counterparty's agreement, applied to all packages. Slower; durable; and it removes the temptation permanently.

3. Claim 71 % and disclose the alternative view. State the assessed position and, separately, that a claim of 78 % would follow if credit were given for delivered spools, with the value quantified at CU 840,000. This lets the recipient decide with full information — which is the definition of not misleading them.

4. Claim 78 % with a note about delivered materials. Not acceptable. The figure entering the valuation is the percentage; the note does not travel with it into the ledger, the cash forecast or the earned value.

5. Claim 78 %. A breach of §5.5.2. It is also the one most likely to be found: the erected quantity is physically countable, and a subsequent measure will show either an implausible catch-up or a reversal that someone will have to explain.

5.5 What you actually say

> "The rules of credit give thirty for fabrication and fifty for erection measured as erected. On that basis it's seventy-one, and I can evidence every point of it. If we want value for the spools on site, let's claim them as materials on site with the delivery records attached — that's a stronger position than an erection percentage I can't support, and it doesn't put the whole application at risk if they audit the measure. If you want to change the rules of credit for next year, I'll draft it, but I can't apply the change retrospectively to this measure."

Keep the verified measurement sheet. In this case the field engineer's record is the evidence, and it is dated.

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6. Case five — the caveat that was removed

Fictitious case. Illustrative figures.

6.1 The situation

You are the reporting lead. You issue the monthly controls report for review with a forecast final cost of **CU 54,700,000** and a stated qualification immediately beneath it:

> "This forecast excludes the cost effect of the unresolved façade variation, currently assessed at CU 2,300,000, which is not yet instructed. Including it, the forecast would be CU 57,000,000."

```
54,700,000 + 2,300,000 = 57,000,000
2,300,000 ÷ 54,700,000 = 0.042 = 4.2 % of the reported forecast
```

The version circulated to the steering group two days later carries the same CU 54,700,000, the same sign-off block with your name in it, and no qualification. Someone has removed the paragraph during formatting. You discover it after the meeting.

6.2 The pressure

There is no pressure in the room, because the room has already happened. The pressure is entirely about what you do now, and it is social rather than commercial: raising it means telling a group of senior people that they were given an incomplete number, embarrassing whoever edited the document, and reopening a meeting that everyone considers closed. The path of least resistance is to fix it quietly in next month's report, where the forecast will "naturally" move to CU 57,000,000 once the variation is instructed.

That path has a specific defect. Next month's report would then show a CU 2,300,000 movement attributed to the variation being instructed — which is not what happened. The movement happened in the document that was edited. Fixing it silently means misstating the reason for a change, which is its own breach of `ETH-01 §5.3`.

6.3 What the Code requires

- `ETH-01 §5.7.1` — an error in issued work is corrected promptly and openly, to everyone who received the original and to anyone known to be relying on it. This applies whether or not you introduced the error.
- `ETH-01 §5.7.2` — the correction states what was wrong, what the corrected position is, and what decisions may have been affected. Quietly reissuing a corrected file is not a correction.
- `ETH-01 §5.1.1` — you must not knowingly transmit, or allow to stand in your name, something materially misleading. A sign-off block carrying your name is a representation.
- `ETH-01 §7.2` — a material misstatement made on your behalf is corrected once you know of it.
- `ETH-01 §5.8` — the record of who changed what, and when, is part of the working papers.

Materiality here is a judgement, and it should be made explicitly rather than assumed. CU 2,300,000 is 4.2 % of the reported forecast. Whether that would change a reasonable reader's decision depends on what the steering group was deciding — but the fact that the qualification was drafted at all is strong evidence that you already considered it material when you wrote it.

6.4 The options, ranked

1. Correct it to the same distribution, within a day, in three sentences. State what the issued report omitted, what the position is including the variation, and that no other figure is affected. Short, factual, and no discussion of who edited it — the correction is about the number, not the person.

2. Correct it and fix the mechanism. Same note, plus a change to how the pack is produced: the report is issued as a locked file from the reporting lead, and any edit after sign-off returns to the author. This converts an incident into a control, and it is the version a governance reviewer will respect.

3. Raise it privately with the chair first, then correct to the full distribution. Acceptable where a private word makes the correction land better. It becomes unacceptable the moment the private word is used as a substitute for the correction.

4. Add the qualification to next month's report. Not acceptable. It leaves a decision standing on an incomplete number for a full cycle and misattributes the movement when it appears.

5. Say nothing, and let the variation instruction explain the movement. A breach of §5.7.1 and §5.3. It is also the option with the longest tail: the sign-off block has your name on it, and the version history will show the paragraph was present when you released it and absent when it was circulated.

6.5 What you actually say

To the distribution, in writing, that day:

> "The report circulated on the 14th omitted a qualification that was in the version I signed off. The forecast of 54.7 excludes the unresolved façade variation, assessed at 2.3. Including it, the forecast is 57.0. No other figure in the report is affected. I'm sorry for the confusion; the qualification will be on the face of the summary page in future."

To whoever edited it, separately and without an audience:

> "The forecast qualification came out of the pack during formatting. I've had to correct it to the distribution because it's a material exclusion. Can we agree that anything after sign-off comes back to me, even for formatting?"

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7. What the five cases have in common

The pressure was never applied to the truth of a figure. It was applied to a **timing**, a **boundary**, a **basis**, a **constraint** or a **paragraph** — the mechanical joints of a reporting system, all of which are legitimately adjustable and none of which the reader can see.

That is why the general defence "every number in the report is correct" is unavailing, and why `ETH-01 §5.3` is written to test the impression created. It is also why the professional response in all five cases has the same three parts:

Separate the number from the narrative. In every case, the honest number and the thing the requester actually wanted could coexist — as a forecast plus a bridge, an index plus an explanation, a date plus a costed compression option, a measure plus a materials claim, a figure plus its qualification. The professional's most useful skill under pressure is finding the presentation that is both honest and useful, because the request usually has a legitimate need buried inside it.

Escalate once, in writing, factually. Not an accusation and not a threat. One paragraph: what I was asked, what I provided, what was agreed. This is the third option practitioners forget exists between silent compliance and resignation, and it is the one `ETH-01 §5.9` actually requires.

Keep the record on the day. Measurement sheets, schedule versions, the email you sent, the date. Every case above turns, eventually, on whether there is a contemporaneous record — and a record made three months later, when it matters, is worth almost nothing.

8. Three sentences worth having ready

The hardest part of every case above is the first ten seconds, when a reasonable-sounding request needs a response and you have not prepared one. Three sentences cover most of them:

- "I can show that as a scenario with the assumptions named, but I can't put it up as the forecast."
- "Can you confirm that instruction in writing so I can reference it in the working papers?"
- "Here's what I can support, and here's what would have to be true for your number — let's put both in front of them."

None of these is confrontational, all three are usable by a junior person to a senior one, and each one converts a private pressure into a documented decision. That conversion is the whole of the professional obligation in `ETH-01 §5.9`: not to win, but to make sure the decision is taken by people who can see what they are deciding.

Related

- `ETH-01 — The PCI code of ethics and professional conduct` — the clauses cited throughout, especially §5
- `ETH-02 — The principles explained` — why the obligations in §5 are drawn where they are
- `ETH-06 — Raising concerns: complaints, investigations, sanctions` — what happens when escalation inside the organisation does not resolve it
- `BPG-06 — Progress measurement and rules of credit` — the method underlying case four
- `BPG-07 — Accruals and cut-off discipline` — the method underlying case two
- `BPG-09 — Estimate at completion: choosing and defending a method` — the forecasting methods behind cases one and two

Sources and standards

- `ETH-01 — The PCI code of ethics and professional conduct` (this framework) — every clause cited.
- PCI Code of Professional Conduct (predecessor instrument), `docs/downloads/code-of-professional-conduct.md`, repository copy read August 2026.

All five cases are invented for teaching. No external source, survey, project record or organisation is cited, referred to or implied, and none was used. All figures are illustrative and were computed for this document.

Status and version

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